DIVINE DRILL



On May 7, BJP leaders in West Bengal were handed a divine directive from the party high command—to visit temples and "seek blessings" for the Indian Army. Ever the obedient flock, many Bengal BJP leaders assembled before temple deities on May 8, hands folded in prayer, cameras rolling, one of them even mouthing a scripted—"This is for our jawans." The ruling Trinamool Congress, of course, could not stop smirking at what it called an attempt to dissipate international tensions with some smoke and incense sticks.

Snake Charmer



Madhya Pradesh CM **Mohan Yadav** has slithered into uncharted territory with his directive for a 'snake census' in the state. The forest department, left scrambling, has turned to the Wildlife Institute of India in Dehradun for help. Yadav's snake fixation isn't new. Some months ago, he wanted the King Cobra to be 'reintroduced' in MP, saying their disappearance had led to a spurt in other snake species. Now, Yadav claims the reptiles themselves have been sidelined in wildlife censuses, prompting what may be India's first official snake roll call.

TERRITORIAL TUSSLE



That Goa CM **Pramod Sawant** and town and country planning (TCP) minister Vishwajit Rane are not the best of mates is no state secret. The tug-of-war is now out in the open, with the personnel department, headed by Sawant, appointing senior town planner R.K. Pandita as chief town planner (Planning)—even as Rane chose Vertika Dagur for the post. Finally, the CM had his way: Pandita will be chief town planner (land use) and head of the department. Dagur will now be chief town planner (admin and planning).

Kaushik Deka with Jeemon Jacob, Dhaval S. Kulkarni, Arkamoy Datta Majumdar, Rahul Noronha

TECH WATCH

By **Ajay Sukumaran**

HIGH ON AI
INDIA HITS TOP LEAGUE



SHUTTERSTOCK

The global AI race is hotting up, and India is now a contender. The country cracked the top 10 in private investment in AI globally, bringing up the rear with $1.4 billion (Rs 11,875 crore), a UN Conference on Trade and Development (UNCTAD) report announced in April. The US was top dog with $67 billion (Rs 5.7 lakh crore) in 2023, while China came in a lowly second with $7.8 billion (Rs 66,163 crore). India did much better in 'cloud infrastructure', where it was tied third with Australia (China and the US took the top two posts). But we did go one up on China in GitHub developers, taking the No. 2 spot with a 12.8 million-strong army. The Americans, with 19.7 million nerds heating up the servers, took the top spot. Apparently, we are now also a leader in 'creating GenAI projects on GitHub'.

SUPERCOMPUTERS
THE POWER OF DESI COMPUTING

Giant databases, parallel processing, supercomputers live in a world that processes data at speeds measured in floating-point operations per second (FLOPS). India's National Supercomputing Mission (NSM) started in 2015 but in just over a decade has set up 34 supercomputers with a combined compute capacity of 35 Petaflops, says a recent 'status report' of the Ministry of Electronics & IT. The first phase involved the installation of six supercomputers, with the focus being on assembling components domestically. By phase two, home-grown value addition rose to 40 per cent, including developing a local software stack. Sources say the final phase is all about full indigenisation, including design, development and manufacturing of key components. And the good part: these supercomputers have been accessed by over 10,000 researchers for their work.



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR